

yet again. With elder brother Mukesh's companies totting up a market capitalisation of \$70 billion and Anil's accounting for \$22 billion, it's clearly not just about gas. Mukesh may call billionaire lists "mere titillations," but he's fighting tooth and nail to protect his flagship company from losing a \$1-billion in profit a year. On the face of it, the battle may be over terms and conditions of gas supply, but any decision will impact both in contrasting ways. What makes this battle such a potboiler is not just the family feud but the breadth of its impact. The state-owned National Thermal Power Corporation and the Government too have been dragged into this feud. This is one story about which there will be much more to come in the new year.

by Malini Bhupta



For almost half a century, Bellary has stayed a Congress bastion, but it took three brothers—sons of a police constable—to change the political landscape of the state forever and help usher in the first BJP Government in south India. The Gali Reddy brothers—Karunakara, Janardhan and Somashekara—are mining barons based in the state's mining capital, Bellary. They cut their teeth in politics when they campaigned for BJP's Sushma Swaraj in 1999 when she contested against Congress's Sonia Gandhi for the Bellary Lok Sabha seat. Their efforts may have been in vain then as Swaraj lost to Sonia but the valuable lesson they learnt has brought them a long way. Thanks to their wealth, the Reddys, two of whom are ministers in the B.S. Yeddyurappa Government, have got a sizable number of legislators in their pockets to administer the occasional pinprick to the chief minister, as they did a month ago when they raised demands that brought the Government to the brink. Though the brothers don't have RSS roots, their money power has given them immense clout in the party. In 2008, when the BJP, with 110 MLAs was short of the magic figure of 113 in the 224-member Karnataka Assembly, the brothers loosened their purse strings to get the numbers necessary for government formation. Yeddyurappa may have no love lost for the brothers but it is clear that the Government he heads cannot do without the Reddys.

by Stephen David

## Rakhi Sawant

### The Rani of PRIME TIME

How many women can reinvent themselves four times in 10 years? Ask Rakhi Sawant. She's been an extra in the movies, a low rent music video star, a highly priced item girl and this year, she was the queen of prime time reality TV. All this thanks to "Jejus" and her viewers. A perfect example of the marriage of celebrati-obsessed news TV with self-promoting reality shows, Sawant made headlines with every act, whether it was choosing her partner on national TV on *Rakhi ka Swayamwar* and getting an opening rating of 4.1 TRP, or trying to raise a succession of variously aged dependents on *Pati Patni Aur Woh* much to Minister of State for Women and Child Development Krishna Tirath's ire. She broke up, made up, broke up again with her sometime fiancé Elesh Parujanwala, made speaking English in plural a fashion statement, and single-handedly kept afloat the wedding lehenga industry. By the year end, she was back where she began, writhing in a music video with reality TV reject IshQ Bector.

by Kaveree Bamzai



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